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From the editor-in-chief

In the wake of last week's bomb blast in Pune, Indian security agencies are focused on what they have codenamed The Karachi Project.

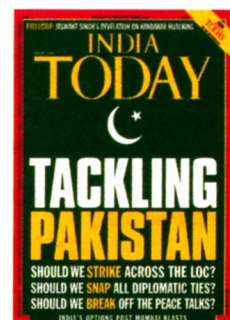
Conceived by Pakistan's ISI in collaboration with 'non-state' terror outfits, it utilises Pakistan-trained Indian operatives to leave behind bags filled with explosives at soft targets in India. The modus operandi has remained the same for some time, only the choice of target—in the latest manifestation an eatery frequented by foreigners—has changed. Indian security agencies have known of the project for some years now but not made it public till Home Secretary G.K. Pillai mentioned it in his briefing after the Pune blast. Named for the Pakistani city which is a sanctuary for Indian fugitives like underworld dons Dawood Ibrahim and Tiger Memon, it is a nefarious joint venture between the Pakistan Army, the ISI and terror groups like the Lashkar-e-Toiba and HUIJI. It is part of a strategy which uses militant groups as an important part of Islamabad's strategic arsenal to counter India's military and economic advantages. Apart from underworld figures, fugitives like the Bhatkal brothers Riyaz and Iqbal and Shahid Bilal are used as 'spotters' to ensure a supply of human operatives to carry out attacks. It was after the arrest of Abdul Khwaja, Bilal's second-in-command, that the security agencies got access to the details of the plot.

The plan is simple: use disaffected Indian youth to carry out terror strikes using locally available bomb material and without suspicions of Pakistan's involvement. Unlike the Mumbai terror attacks of 26/11 which left behind irrefutable evidence of Pakistan's involvement, the Karachi Project uses only Indian nationals recruited by Lashkar spotters either in India, Pakistan or in Bangladesh and indoctrinated using propaganda videos showing the Babri Masjid demolition and Gujarat riots. The Indian Mujahideen, a Lashkar front which carried out a series of attacks in Delhi, Jaipur, Hyderabad, Ahmedabad and Mumbai, was set up precisely for this purpose around 2007. After completion of the training, many of the agents were infiltrated into India as sleeper cells, waiting for the command to strike. A key addition to the project was the use of foreign nationals like David Headley to travel around India selecting targets and activating sleeper cells.

Our cover story reveals the details of the Karachi Project and analyses the seriousness of the threat in the context of whether Indian security and intelligence agencies are adequately equipped to thwart their evil designs. Backed by views of members of the INDIA TODAY Board of Experts on Security and Terror along with prominent security analysts from Pakistan, we also examine what stand India should take for the upcoming talks with Pakistan keeping in view the Pune blast and its ramifications.

Kashmir is obviously a central issue and part of the cover story package looks at its newly charged security situation and the Centre's new rehabilitation strategy and its impact on the Indo-Pakistan talks later this month. Whatever strategy the UPA Government adopts in the wake of the Pune blast, one thing is abundantly clear: the road to peace will continue to be as challenging as any war. And there is no other choice but to stay the course.

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)



OUR JULY 2006 COVER



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